One tool. Seven departments.

A standard CRM tracks the sale and stops there. Customer Intelligence keeps the conversation alive across every department that touches a customer. Sales, Marketing, Support, Finance, Operations, Product, Leadership — each sees what they need to see.

CONTENTS

The situation — WE ARE NOW ABOUT THAT THE FIRST TIME

The idea — THE FIRST TIME WE ARE

How we work — OVER SEVERAL, ON

What is done — A LOT, THE FIRST TIME

What it is for — THE FIRST TIME WE

How we build it — THE FIRST TIME WE

The ending — THE FIRST TIME

Tim Kindberg
Tim Cole

We are more complex than our tools suggest

The lab is not a single business. We run seven departments under one roof, each with its own customers, its own tools, its own rhythm. Our tools assume one company, and we spend all our year wrong communication failures turn real, immediate consequences.

A client wants a web-based manager with a build job. That job eventually needs quotes, approvals, purchasing, scheduling, a Slack channel, and a bill to pay. Each of those lives in a different tool, and the job lives in none of them. Information about the job must be typed into each tool by hand, and when one tool changes, everyone else waits to find out. Nothing knows the whole job. Nothing knows who is waiting on what. Nothing knows when it is late, and when they have committed to something.

We want to get this right for our own work first, and then for the industry. Slower, thoughtful tools often do not survive in the real world. We want to build tools that people want to use every day, and that means they must fit the way we actually work, not the way a textbook says we should work. We want to be honest about what we can do and what we cannot do, and we want to be open about our mistakes so others can learn from them.

That works — until someone is sick, something changes at the last minute, or two departments are operating from a different version of the same brief.

We have been very good at making it work anyway. But there is a cost. Long hours chasing information that should be simple to obtain, delayed jobs, misunderstandings between departments, and the constant friction of running a commercial operation through disconnected tools.

One place where every job lives

We want to build a single system that covers the whole lifecycle of a job, from the first enquiry to the final invoice. Quotes, purchase requisitions, production, and a customer portal, all in one place. Each department sees the part of the job that matters to them, and the system knows the whole job.

Business management is the common language that ties all of these tools together. It is where enquiries become jobs, where jobs become quotes, where quotes become purchase orders, and where the final invoice closes the loop. It is the place where we can see, at any moment, what is in progress, what is late, what is waiting on a customer, and what we have committed to spend and to bill.

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WE'RE NOW

Seven departments. One job.

Every department at The Lab has two sides: the management and planning side, and the execution side. And every department can be the first point of contact for a new job.

This is important because most tools assume a simple entry point — someone fills in a form, and the work begins. But in our business, we do not work that way, and we should not have to. A tool built for The Lab needs to support that, and it can help anyone else who works the way we do, or wants to.

PROCUREMENT
PRODUCTION
SALES & MARKETING
CUSTOMER PORTAL
Business management
Job data
Job lifecycle
Customer data
Supplier data
Production data
Procurement data
Sales data
Customer data
Supplier data
Production data
Procurement data
Sales data
Customer data
Supplier data
Production data
Procurement data
Sales data